

Title:

Coffin's Death

### Chapter 1: The Nail That Whispers

It wasn't the coffin's wood that frightened him—it was the sound of the nail.

One nail.

Bent slightly to the left.

Not rusted, not new.

Just... too deliberate.

It lay on the table in the old undertaker's shed, humming with silence. The air around it seemed heavier than usual, as if time had knelt there and wept once before moving on. No one touched it. No one dared.

Jared Coffin—whose ancestors built tombs before they built homes—stood alone under the flickering bulb. He wasn't a man who feared death; he wore it like an old coat passed down. His father was buried in pine, his mother in oak, his brother in fire. But Jared? He never chose.

That nail was choosing for him.

He wasn't dead yet. Not entirely.

But something in him had stopped breathing long ago.

Outside, the wind screamed like a jealous lover. The undertaker's dog, blind and nameless, barked at shadows that hadn't moved in years.

Jared's fingers hovered above the nail. It didn't move. But it watched. In its silence was a voice older than the town, older than sin. A voice that knew what was buried in Jared's walls... and who.

He hadn't opened that door in 27 years.

He would tonight.

### Chapter 2: The Room Behind the Room

There are doors, and then there are thresholds — spaces you cross not with footsteps, but with soul.

Jared Coffin reached for the brass knob that hadn't turned since the year his mother bled red onto white sheets in that room. The key was still buried beneath the floorboard in the corner. He remembered hiding it with shaking hands and dirt-caked nails, whispering things to the floor that no boy should ever have to whisper.

He didn't retrieve the key.

He didn't need to.

The door opened on its own.

A rush of stale air greeted him, thick with mold, grief, and the strange sweetness of rot that only memory can ferment. The wallpaper had peeled like dead skin, curling at the edges. The mirror above the dresser was cracked, but it still reflected him — older, hollower, but him nonetheless.

She was still in there.

Not her body.

Her presence.

Her song.

That same humming that crawled through the nail in the shed echoed from the corners of the room. It wasn't a tune; it was a warning. A lullaby for the damned.

He stepped in.

The door didn't close behind him. It disappeared.

This was no longer the Coffin house. This was no longer earth. This was the space between last breath and the scream that follows.

He reached toward the cradle.

Empty.

Yet heavy.

His name was carved into the wood of the cradle — not as a baby, but as a grave.

"Here lies Jared Coffin. Born once. Died often."

### Chapter 3: Born Once, Died Often

There is something unnatural about seeing your name on a coffin before you die. But to see it in a cradle?

That is a curse.

Jared ran his finger across the carved letters. They hadn't been chiseled with tools. These marks were too rough, too alive, as if made by nails still attached to trembling hands. The kind of hands that scratch through wood when breath runs out.

He could almost hear them — the scratching.

Soft at first. Then louder. Then screaming.

The walls began to move, not as objects shift, but as living things do — pulsing, breathing, recoiling. The wallpaper buckled like flesh rejecting a needle. A crack in the ceiling opened slowly like a mouth yawning, and somewhere beneath the floorboards, something giggled.

Not a child.

Not quite.

He had no memory of having a brother buried beneath this room. Yet he knew, without logic or timeline, that someone shared his blood and had never seen the sky. The room remembered what he chose to forget.

There were four baby shoes nailed to the wall. Two lefts. Two rights. None matched.

He stepped back, heart pounding like footsteps on the stairs — fast, approaching.

And they were.

He turned.

The girl stood in the corner.

Hair over her face.

Hands like spiders clutching something invisible.

She didn't move. But her shadow danced, climbing the walls like ivy in reverse.

"You left me," she said.

Her voice was not angry. Not sad. Just empty.

Like a coffin before its first breath.

Chapter 4: The Girl Without a Name

She wasn't there before — Jared was sure of it. But now she stood as if she had always stood. A fixture. A haunting. A truth too ancient for time to erase.

Her dress was white once, now yellowed and frayed like forgotten pages. Her bare feet made no sound on the rotting floor. Her hands clutched the air as if strangling something unseen, or perhaps, holding the memory of something once alive.

"You left me," she said again.

The voice didn't match her body. It was older — cracked with age, dusted with time. Like the room had borrowed someone else's sorrow just to make her speak.

Jared tried to answer. No words came. His mouth opened but his lungs forgot how to exhale. His throat filled with rust. Not from blood — but from guilt.

She took a step forward. The cradle creaked. The mirror cracked a little more.

"Who are you?" he finally whispered.

She tilted her head. The shadow behind her twitched.

"You named me once," she said. "Before you buried me."

His legs weakened. A memory rose — not fully formed, just flashes: thunder in the distance, lightning over the hill, digging with bare hands, crying not from sadness but confusion.

He had forgotten what he did that night.

But the ground hadn't.

"You said you'd come back for me," she continued, her eyes still hidden beneath her hair.

A trickle of cold air slid along his spine. Not air. Breath.

Something was breathing on his neck.

He turned. Nothing.

When he looked back — she was gone.

The shoes were gone.

The cradle was a coffin now.

And inside it... was his mother.

## Chapter 5: Mothers Who Never Sleep

Her eyes were open. But she did not blink.

She lay with her hands folded across her chest — not in peace, but restraint. The fingers were bound together with a red string, one Jared hadn't seen since he was a boy. It was the same string she used to tie his toys, his books, his hands when he misbehaved.

"She never slept," he muttered aloud. "Not even in death."

A voice replied — not hers.

"She waits."

The room had darkened. The only light came from the mirror, which now reflected nothing but fog. No walls, no room, no Jared. Just mist and shapes within it — like figures trapped under ice.

The coffin shook.

Jared stepped back.

The lid closed on its own, sealing with a soft click — like a lock turning inside a ribcage.

He wanted to run.

But the door had vanished, and the girl — she was in the mirror now, floating behind him, hands pressed against the glass.

The fog inside the mirror whispered.

"Jared Coffin, firstborn. Jared Coffin, graveborn. Jared Coffin, who ran."

He screamed — not aloud, but inwards, where it mattered more.

And something inside him answered.

## Chapter 6: The Weight of a Name

The mirror didn't break.

It breathed.

With every syllable of his name, it fogged and cleared like lungs struggling through the cold. Jared wanted to look away, but it held him. Not by reflection — by recognition. This wasn't a mirror. It was a memory with glass skin.

His name was heavy. Not the way guilt is heavy. The way soil is heavy when you're underneath it.

He pressed his palm against the surface.

It felt warm.

And then it opened — not shattered, not cracked — opened, as if it had always been a door.

Through the fog, a hallway stretched. Wooden. Damp. Familiar.

He had walked here before. Barefoot. As a boy. Carrying something.

Something wrapped in a blanket.

The same red string trailed behind it.

He walked in now, older, slower. The past echoed in reverse — footsteps moving ahead of him instead of behind. He was chasing himself.

Or maybe running from what was catching up.

## Chapter 7: Where the Dead Are Waiting

The hallway was impossibly long. It curved slightly — enough to feel wrong, unnatural, like a spine too twisted to stand upright.

Each door he passed was marked.

Not with numbers.

With dates.

Some old. Some recent. One had tomorrow's date.

He didn't open any.

Until he came to the one that bore no number, no mark — only his own bloody handprint.

It was fresh.

Still warm.

He didn't remember leaving it.

The knob resisted, but not enough. Like the door wanted him to believe he had a choice.

He stepped in.

Darkness swallowed him, then spat him into a room filled with chairs — empty, facing him. All except one. In it sat a man with Jared's face, but a stranger's eyes.

The man smiled.

"We've been expecting you."

## Chapter 8: The Audience of None

There were no mouths among the crowd of chairs, but Jared felt watched.

The other him stood and walked forward. Not a reflection — something worse. A version of Jared unbound by regret. He didn't limp with trauma. He didn't flinch at memory. He wore pain like armor.

Jared stepped back.

The other Jared stepped forward.

"You buried it," he said. "But it still grew."

The lights above flickered, then focused on the ground between them — a box.

No longer a coffin.

A gift.

Wrapped in black ribbon. Still. Breathing.

“Open it,” the other Jared whispered. “It’s everything you’ve forgotten.”

Jared knelt. His fingers trembled around the ribbon.

Inside wasn’t a body.

It was a voice.

His own, from childhood.

Screaming.

### Chapter 9: When Screams Become Soil

The sound poured from the box like smoke. It didn’t rise — it sank. Filling the room like floodwater, up to the knees, then the chest, then over the mouth. Jared could no longer speak, only listen.

The child’s scream shifted into a chant. A name.

Not his own.

“Lenora.”

He dropped the box.

It spilled photographs.

Every one was torn — his mother’s face scratched out, a baby blurred, a red string crossing through each frame like a wound stitched wrong.

He fell to his knees.

The other Jared knelt beside him.

“You let her die,” he whispered. “Because you couldn’t remember whether she was real.”

A small voice — the girl’s — echoed now from above:

“You chose to forget me.”

And the ceiling cracked.

Dust fell.

Then silence.

### Chapter 10: Coffin’s Death

This was no longer a house.

It was no longer a room.

Jared stood at the edge of a black field. The box was gone. The mirrors were gone. But in the soil at his feet, names began to appear — written by unseen hands. Hundreds.

Each one was his.

Different spellings. Different lives. Same fate.

The sky opened — not with light, but with memory.

His mother's lullaby, half-sung.

His sister's laugh, never fully heard.

The shovel he held once, covered in rain and tears.

And the coffin — his real coffin — rose from the earth.

Not nailed shut.

Wide open.

Inside it was a letter.

To him.

From Lenora.

"I don't hate you. I was never angry.

You just never looked back.

And now, it's time to rest, Jared.

We all need someone to close the lid."

He wept.

For the first time in years, he wept.

Then, with shaking hands, he lay down.

The coffin closed.

And this time, he heard no nail.

Just the soft exhale of peace.